4 – Selecting Sources

MLI Rubrics Project – Lesson 4.mp4

Welcome to **Lesson 4: Selecting Supporting Sources.**

By the end of this lesson, you'll understand:

- What a supporting source is and why it's essential
- How to select or create effective supporting sources
- The qualities that make a document valid and useful
- And common pitfalls to avoid when finding sources.

Let's start with the basics.

What Is a Supporting Source?

A **supporting source** is the file or supporting document that provides the necessary data, evidence, or context that the AI model needs to answer your prompt accurately. You will need to have all of these sources and files collected and submitted with your prompt.

Think of it this way: if you were tackling a complex professional assignment – whether that's drafting a valuation memo, writing a legal argument, diagnosing a patient, or proposing a market strategy – you wouldn't do it from memory. You'd pull together the source material, the data, the case details, or the reports that inform your thinking.

That's what a supporting document is. It's the model's equivalent of **the materials an expert would consult** before delivering a high-quality, professional work product.

Why Supporting Sources Matter

Supporting sources are essential for three reasons.

1. First, they **prevent the model from guessing based on prior knowledge alone.**
2. Second, they **simulate real-world conditions,** where professionals rely on data, reports, and client materials to do their jobs.
3. And third, they ensure that the task is truly **reasoning-based, not recall-based.**

If the model can answer your prompt correctly **without referencing the supporting document,** the task probably isn't sufficiently challenging or valid for this project. Regardless of the domain, the document should contain rich, relevant information necessary to complete the task.

Criteria for Strong Sources

Now let's cover the **criteria for a strong supporting source.**

A high-quality document must be:

- **Directly Relevant** – it needs to contain the data, insights, or context required to answer the prompt. If it's off-topic, it's not useful.
- **Sufficiently Detailed** – the document should force the model to synthesize information, not just extract a single fact or sentence.
- **Professional and Realistic**. It should reflect authentic industry documents in tone, format, and complexity.
- **Accurately Cited, if sourced externally.** If you're using a real document, you must cite the source.
- And finally, **Properly Formatted.** Submit clean, legible documents that are either PDF or CSV files (no other format is accepted).

Let's consider what might constitute **effective supporting sources** – though again, this is really something you will need to figure out what makes the most sense for your profession and for the given task that you have established in the prompt.

- In finance, it could be an anonymized financial statement comparing two firms, detailing revenue, profit margins, and debt profiles.
- In medicine, it might be a structured case study that includes a patient's history, symptoms, lab results, and imaging summaries.
- In law, you might provide a memo summarizing state-specific rulings on employment law.
- And in consulting, it could be a market research document analyzing competitors, consumer trends, and regulatory barriers for a new market.

What all of these have in common is that they provide **enough information for the model to engage in multi-step reasoning – not just retrieval.**

A few other notes:

- **There is no maximum number of documents** that you should upload. We do not have a hard count requirement but you should not add documents that are not used towards the original prompt.

- **You can consider using digital work that you've completed as context documents**. Just make sure you remove any PII or confidential information before submission.

- For this project, pay-walled information is permissible for file use as prompt context.
    - Any web-based sources that you'd like to use should be converted into PDFs or .csv files before being added into the prompt context

    - Excel files must be converted to .csv before uploading

- **You should not paste a URL link and expect the model to be able to read it** – passing on data as a link in the prompt is not acceptable. You must include a file in the acceptable format (PDF or CSV).

- **You should reference the names of the documents that you upload in your prompt**.

- **Make sure your sources do not contain contradictory information** – your sources should not contradict each other.

So in summary, a well-crafted grounding document:

- Forces the model to engage deeply with professional material
- Prevents shortcutting with memorized or general knowledge
- And anchors your prompt in realistic, domain-specific data.

In the next lesson, we'll explore **how to write rubrics that define expert performance** – ensuring we can objectively evaluate the model's output against professional standards. After you've completed the comprehension quiz, head to **Lesson 5: Writing Rubrics.**